

BLACKPAST



Mount Zion United Methodist Church (1816-)

September 12, 2020 / Contributed By: Velma Ruth



Mount Zion United Methodist Church in Washington D.C.
Courtesy AgnosticPreachersKid (CC BY-SA 3.0)

Founded in 1816, Mt. Zion United Methodist Church, the oldest continuously operating African American church in Washington DC, is located at 1334 29th Street NW. The Georgetown community where the church now sits, was a central port for slave and tobacco trading in the early 1800s. At the time, one third of Georgetown's population was Black with half enslaved and half free. The founders of Mt. Zion UMC were originally members of the Montgomery Street Church (now Dumbarton UMC) established in 1772. That church was 50% African American. In 1814, Following dissatisfaction with Montgomery Street segregation, Black members formed their

own congregation called “The Meeting House.” Founders bought land on Mill Street (now 27th Street) from Henry Foxall, an officer of Montgomery Street Church. The Meeting House continued to be supervised and served by ministers of Montgomery.

The new church’s Sabbath School provided education for adults and children from 1823 to 1862. Later from 1840 and through Reconstruction, the church hosted schools sponsored by Pennsylvania Freedmen’s Relief Association and additional groups.

The name changed to “Mt. Zion Methodist Episcopal Church” in 1844 at the recommendation of Rev. Stephen Roszel, an anti-slavery leader and pastor of Montgomery. Following pushes for Black ministers to lead Black churches, in 1849 multiple Mt. Zion members left the church to start Union Wesley African Methodist Episcopal Zion Church, John Wesley African Methodist Episcopal Zion Church, and Ebenezer African Methodist Episcopal Church, all in the District of Columbia. Before and during the Civil War, Mt. Zion was a station on the Underground Railroad, using a vault in the Old Methodist Burying Ground to hide runaway slaves for their passage north.

The current 29th Street location of Mt. Zion Church is on land purchased by the congregation in 1875 for \$2,581 from Alfred Pope, a local Black businessman and Trustee of Mt. Zion. Mt. Zion relocated to the new site in 1880, after the original church structure burned down. The first cornerstone was laid in 1876, and construction was completed in 1884 under leadership of pastors Rev. Alexander Dennis and Rev. Edgar Murphy.

By 1896, Mt. Zion church membership grew to 700 people. Construction and expansions continued with a new community

center called “Community House” in 1920 on property adjacent to Mt. Zion and led by Emma Williams, a social worker.

Membership declined in the late 1930s and 1940s as the Black population of Georgetown relocated as Whites now dominated this upper income neighborhood. In the mid-1950s, however, Mt. Zion’s membership grew again as it welcomed parishioners from the wider Metro DC area through provision of a transportation service. Mt. Zion owned three buses by the mid-1960s that brought congregants from across the city and its immediate suburbs.

In 1975, Mt. Zion Church and the adjacent Mt. Zion Cemetery became Historical Landmarks on the National Register of Historical Places.

Mt. Zion’s current membership includes multi-generational families since founding, and members from the wider Washington DC area as well as the Virginia and Maryland suburbs. Few members currently live in Georgetown. Mt. Zion continues community services throughout Greater Washington and maintains active involvement in Black History and Historical Tourism.

About the Author



VELMA RUTH

Velma Anne Ruth is President of ABS Community Research, a nonprofit established in 2001 to support community partnerships between health and human services, education, labor, and justice.

Through ABS, Velma has volunteered and consulted in advocacy and development support to a range of organizations and projects. Beneficiaries include U.S. Veterans, Black History programs, Gospel Music programs, African village associations, public-private partnerships in Africa, and more across multiple continents.

In 2013, UN Economic & Social Council affiliate Universal Peace Federation appointed Velma an Ambassador for Peace, which is a certificate of advocacy-related diplomatic status to the United Nations awarded to selected government officials, diplomats, business leaders, philanthropists, and activists. Velma has also worked extensively with U.S. Federal, Foreign Government, and United Nations agencies, committees, and officials in matters related to human rights, democracy, security, and economics. Velma has Bachelors of Interdisciplinary Studies in Psychology and the Visual & Performing Arts, and a Masters of Education in Psychology and Criminal Justice. She is based between the Washington, D.C. area and central Pennsylvania.

Categories:

African American Businesses and Institutions

African American History

Tags:

19th Century (1800-1899)

Military Conflict - Civil War

Religious Organizations - Methodist

Slave/Freedmen

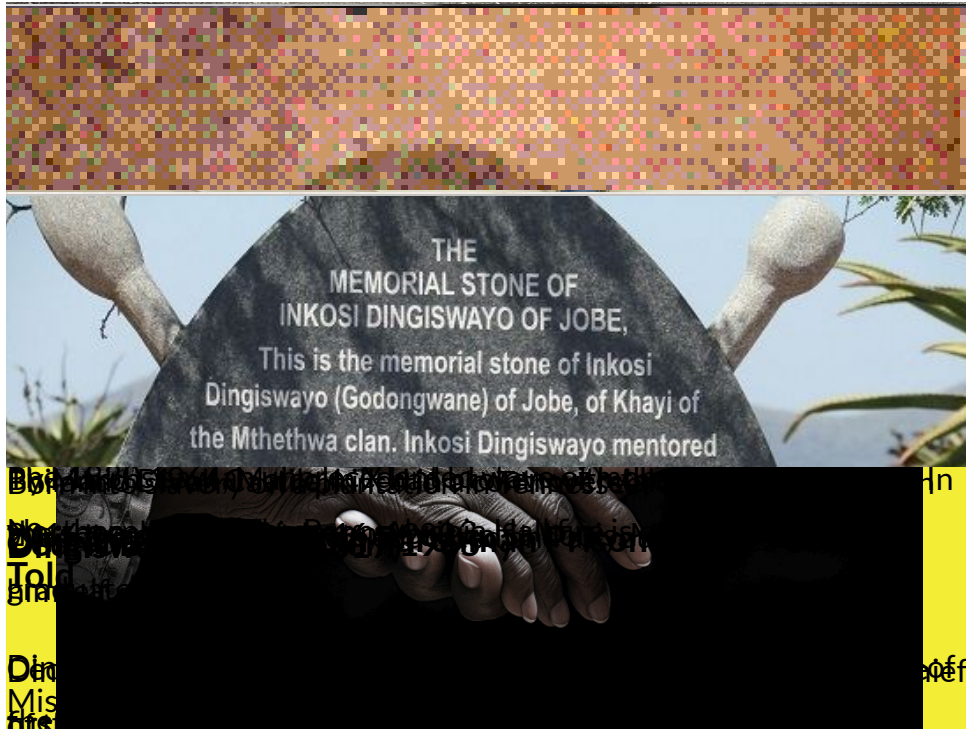
United States - Maryland

United States - Virginia

United States-Washington D.C

Similar Posts

Recent Posts



**THE
MEMORIAL STONE OF
INKOSI DINGISWAYO OF JOBE,**
This is the memorial stone of Inkosi
Dingiswayo (Godongwane) of Jobe, of Khayi of
the Mthethwa clan. Inkosi Dingiswayo mentored
BlackPast.org and helped to create the BlackPast.org website.

Do you find this information helpful?

A small donation would help us keep this available to all.

Forego a bottle of soda and donate its cost to us for the information you just learned, and feel good about helping to make it available to everyone.

BlackPast.org is a 501(c)(3) non-profit and our EIN is 26-1625373. Your donation is fully tax-deductible.

DONATE

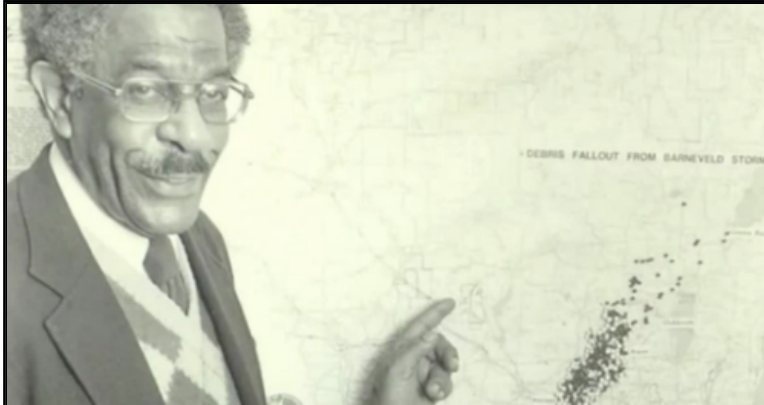
CITE THIS ENTRY IN APA FORMAT:

Ruth, V. (2020, September 12). *Mount Zion United Methodist Church (1816-)*. BlackPast.org.
<https://www.blackpast.org/african-american-history/mount-zion-united-methodist-church-1816/>

SOURCE OF THE AUTHOR'S INFORMATION:

Mount Zion United Methodist Church,
http://www.mtzionumcdc.org/church_online_315.aspx;
Kathleen Menzie Lesko, Valerie Babb, and Carroll R. Gibbs, *Black Georgetown Remembered* (Washington, D.C.: Georgetown University Press, 1991);
<http://press.georgetown.edu/book/georgetown/black-georgetown-remembered>; "Mount Zion Cemetery,
"National Park Service Registry
<https://www.nps.gov/nr/travel/wash/dc10.htm>; "Mount Zion United Methodist Church: Historic American Buildings Survey," *Library of Congress*,
<http://www.loc.gov/pictures/item/dc0182/>; Pauline Gaskins Mitchell, "The History of Mt. Zion United Methodist Church and Mt. Zion Cemetery," *Columbia Historical Society Records*, Vol. 51, pp. 103-118; Historical Society of Washington, D.C. (1984),
<https://www.jstor.org/stable/40067847>.

Further Reading



Charles Edward Anderson (1919-1994)

Charles Edward Anderson, meteorologist, Air Force officer, and weather officer, was born August 13, 1919 in the inner suburbs of St. Louis, Missouri on a...

READ MORE

May 20th, 2018



Marnesba Tillmon Tackett (1908-2007)

“Image Ownership: Public Domain” Civil rights activist and education reformer Marnesba Tillmon Tackett was born in St. Louis, Missouri, to...

READ MORE

April 24th, 2016



Ed Bullins (1935-)

Playwright Ed Bullins was born in Philadelphia, Pennsylvania in 1935. He was raised by his mother on Philadelphia's North side,...

READ MORE

November 20th, 2007



Moroni, Comoros (10th Century-)

Moroni is a coastal town that serves as the capital of Comoros, an archipelago in the Indian Ocean. In 2003...

[READ MORE](#)

December 22nd, 2014



Coleridge-Taylor Perkinson (1932-2004)

Image Ownership: Center for Black Music Research (Fair Use) Musician, composer, and conductor Coleridge-Taylor Perkinson was born on June 14,...

READ MORE

January 28th, 2013



John Lewis Waller (1850-1907)

John L. Waller was a career Republican and activist who played a significant role in Kansas politics. He was born...

READ MORE

January 31st, 2007



Raymond Aloysius Brown (1915-2009)

Raymond A. Brown, a prominent civil rights activist, attorney, and military officer was born on May 6, 1915 in Fernandina...

[**READ MORE**](#)

February 28th, 2020



Lovie Yancey (1912–2008)

“Image Ownership: Public Domain” Lovie Louise Yancey was the African American founder of the Fatburger restaurant chain. She was born...

READ MORE

September 22nd, 2015

CONTACT BLACKPAST

Contact Us

Write For Us

How You Can Help Us

Accessibility



©2007–2025 BLACKPAST.ORG. ALL RIGHTS RESERVED.

BLACKPAST.ORG IS A 501(C)(3) NONPROFIT ORGANIZATION. THE EIN IS 26-1625373. ALL DONATIONS ARE TAX DEDUCTIBLE.